

THE IMPERFECTION OF HUMAN OATHS AND THE CHRISTIAN CALL TO TRUTHFUL SPEECH

A Biblical-Theological Research Paper on Human Sinfulness, Human Mutability, Divine Faithfulness, Evil Oaths, and the Principle “Do Not Take Oath”

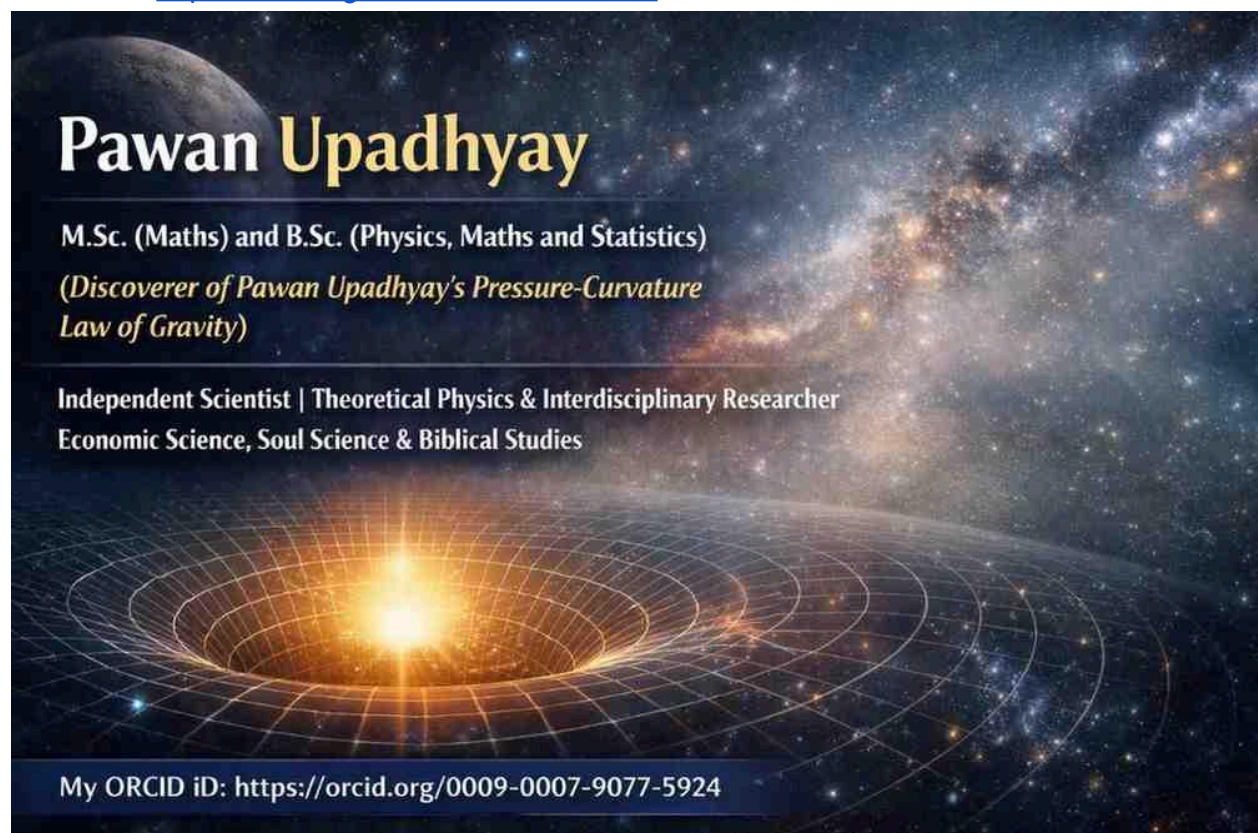
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Abstract

This research paper develops a biblical-theological argument for the Christian principle that human persons should not take oaths. The central thesis is that an oath asks a finite, mutable, and morally imperfect human being to attach exceptional certainty to a spoken commitment, while human knowledge, intentions, circumstances, desires, and conduct remain subject to change. Because every human being is affected by sin, a human oath can become false, empty, broken, manipulative, corrupt, or destructive. The paper therefore distinguishes the absolute faithfulness of God from the fallible promises of human beings.

The argument proceeds especially from Matthew 5:33–37 and James 5:12, where disciples are directed away from oath-taking and toward truthful “yes” and “no.” It also considers the Old Testament background of vows and oaths, the New Testament witness to God's faithfulness, Christ as the fulfillment of God's promises, and the theological significance of the distinction between divine and human speech.

The paper develops a proposed fourfold conceptual framework:

1. **Divine Oath**
2. **Holy Oath**
3. **Simple Truthful Speech**
4. **Evil Oath**

This fourfold terminology is presented as a constructive theological model rather than as a formal biblical taxonomy.

The paper argues that Christ's teaching should not be reduced merely to a prohibition of particular oath formulas. Its deeper ethical force is that Christian truthfulness must not depend upon an oath. The Christian should speak truthfully without invoking sacred objects, God, heaven, earth, institutions, or other witnesses to strengthen ordinary speech.

The paper also argues that an “evil oath” may be identified ethically when a solemn commitment is directed toward deception, injustice, violence, corruption, persecution, false accusation, concealment of wrongdoing, or harm to innocent persons. Such an oath has no moral authority merely because it has been sworn.

The conclusion is practical: Christians should cultivate truthful speech, faithful action, repentance when they fail, and refusal of sinful commitments. The Christian answer to human unreliability is not a stronger human oath but deeper truthfulness under God.

Keywords: Christian ethics; oath; swearing; Matthew 5:33–37; James 5:12; truthfulness; human sin; human mutability; divine faithfulness; evil oath; promise; Trinity; Christology.

1. Introduction

The question of whether Christians should take oaths is not merely a question about vocabulary. It is a question about truth, authority, conscience, human weakness, divine faithfulness, justice, and Christian discipleship.

Human societies have frequently used oaths to strengthen statements and commitments. A person may say, “I swear,” “I swear before God,” “I swear on my honor,” or “I swear that this is true.” The intention is normally to communicate seriousness and credibility.

But Christianity raises a deeper question:

Why should a truthful statement require an oath in the first place?

If a person’s “yes” is true, why must the person add an oath to make it believable?

If a person’s “no” is true, why must the person invoke heaven, earth, God, family, honor, or another authority?

Jesus Christ addresses precisely this problem in Matthew 5:33–37. In the Sermon on the Mount, Jesus teaches his disciples concerning oaths and concludes:

“Let your word be ‘Yes, Yes’ or ‘No, No.’”

James gives a remarkably similar instruction:

“Do not swear, either by heaven or by earth or by any other oath, but let your yes be yes and your no be no.”

These passages establish a powerful Christian principle: **truth should not depend upon oath-taking.**

The purpose of this paper is to develop that principle systematically.

The argument begins with the nature of human beings. Human persons are finite. Human knowledge is limited. Human intentions can change. Human circumstances change. Human desires change. Human judgments can be mistaken. Human beings can sin. Therefore, a human being cannot guarantee future behavior with divine certainty.

A human oath may express a sincere intention. A person may honestly intend to fulfill an oath. A person may even fulfill it. Nevertheless, the person remains a finite and morally imperfect human being.

Therefore:

A human oath cannot become a Divine Oath merely because human beings use solemn or religious language.

This distinction is fundamental.

God's faithfulness is not merely human faithfulness multiplied to a greater degree. God's faithfulness belongs to God's character. Human faithfulness is creaturely, dependent, and vulnerable.

Consequently, the Christian should not seek divine-level certainty through human oath-taking.

The central proposal of this research paper is therefore:

Because human beings are imperfect, mutable, finite, and affected by sin, they should not take oaths as a means of establishing truth or guaranteeing absolute future faithfulness. Christians should instead practice simple truthful speech and righteous action.

2. Research Question

The principal research question is:

Why, within Christian theology, should imperfect human persons refrain from taking oaths?

Several subsidiary questions follow.

1. What is an oath?
2. What does Jesus teach about oath-taking in Matthew 5:33–37?
3. What does James teach about oath-taking in James 5:12?
4. How does human sinfulness affect human speech?
5. How does human mutability affect promises and oaths?
6. Can human beings make a commitment that possesses divine perfection?
7. What is the difference between God's oath and a human oath?
8. How should "Divine Oath" be understood?
9. Can Christ be described as the Divine Oath within a theological framework?
10. What is an "evil oath"?
11. Can an oath directed against an innocent person have moral authority?
12. What should a Christian do after making a sinful oath?
13. What is the relationship between oath-taking and simple truthful speech?
14. How should this theology address legal or judicial oaths?
15. What are the practical implications for Christian life and community?

3. Central Thesis

The central thesis of this research paper is:

Imperfect human persons cannot take an oath that possesses the absolute perfection, immutability, omniscience, and faithfulness of God. Human beings are finite, changeable, and affected by sin. Consequently, human oaths can become false, empty, broken, manipulative, corrupt, or evil. Therefore, Christians should not depend upon oath-taking for truthfulness but should follow Christ's command to let their yes be yes and their no be no.

This thesis does not require the claim that every human oath necessarily becomes false.

That distinction is important.

A human being may say something truthfully. A human being may make a sincere promise. A human being may keep a commitment.

But:

human sincerity is not divine immutability.

human faithfulness is not divine omniscience.

human commitment is not divine sovereignty.

human speech is not divine speech.

A person may be faithful, but no person becomes God by taking an oath.

Therefore the theological question is not simply whether human beings *can* keep oaths.

The deeper question is whether Christians **need** oath-taking and whether oath-taking is consistent with the higher principle of truthful Christian speech.

The answer developed here is no.

4. Methodology

This study uses a biblical-theological method.

The primary biblical passages are:

- Matthew 5:33–37
- James 5:12
- Hebrews 6:13–18
- 2 Corinthians 1:18–20
- John 1:1–14
- Romans 3:23
- Matthew 12:34
- James 4:13–15
- Leviticus 19:12
- Numbers 30
- Deuteronomy 23:21–23

The study also engages theological and scholarly discussions concerning Jesus' teaching on oaths.

There is a genuine scholarly debate concerning the precise scope of Jesus' prohibition. Some interpreters understand Matthew 5:33–37 as an absolute prohibition of oath-taking. Others understand Jesus as attacking manipulative, evasive, or deceptive forms of oath-taking.

Akio Ito argues that the prohibition is particularly radical and comprehensive. Other scholarship, including Don B. Garlington's work, demonstrates that the question remains debated and that some Christian interpreters have allowed particular forms of oath-taking.

This paper adopts a **strict Christian non-oath interpretation**, while acknowledging the existence of alternative interpretations.

The paper also uses the term **“Divine Oath”** constructively. Scripture speaks explicitly about God's promises, God's faithfulness, God's oath, Christ as the Word, and Christ as the “Yes” of God's promises. But Scripture does not formally present the Trinity under the technical title “Divine Oath.”

Therefore:

“Divine Oath” is a theological concept developed in this paper to describe divine faithfulness and self-witness, not a claim that Scripture gives the Trinity that exact title.

The same methodological caution applies to the fourfold framework.

5. What Is an Oath?

An oath is generally a solemn affirmation or commitment intended to establish credibility or seriousness by invoking an authority, witness, sacred reality, or consequence.

The structure can be represented as:

Statement + solemn invocation + commitment = oath

For example:

“I swear before God that this is true.”

The speaker is attempting to establish greater credibility than ordinary speech appears to provide.

This creates an important theological question.

Why is ordinary speech insufficient?

If “yes” is true, why does “I swear yes” become more true?

If “no” is true, why does “I swear no” become more truthful?

The answer is that an oath does not actually change the truth value of a statement.

If something is true, an oath does not make it more true.

If something is false, an oath does not make it true.

Therefore the oath is not the source of truth.

Truth exists independently of the oath.

The oath attempts to persuade the listener that the speaker's statement should be trusted.

This distinction is critical.

An oath cannot transform falsehood into truth.

An oath cannot transform a sinner into a sinless person.

An oath cannot transform a finite person into an infinite person.

An oath cannot transform mutable human thinking into divine immutability.

An oath cannot transform a human promise into a divine promise.

6. The Old Testament Background of Oaths

The Old Testament contains numerous references to oaths and vows.

For example, Leviticus 19:12 warns against swearing falsely by God's name.

Numbers 30 discusses vows and obligations.

Deuteronomy 23:21–23 addresses vows made to God.

These passages demonstrate that biblical revelation takes human promises seriously.

The Old Testament does not treat words as meaningless.

A promise matters.

A vow matters.

A commitment matters.

False speech matters.

The misuse of God's name matters.

This background is essential for understanding Jesus.

Jesus does not teach that truthfulness is unimportant.

He teaches that truthfulness must become deeper.

The problem is not simply whether a particular formula has technically been pronounced.

The problem is the character of the speaker.

The person who tells the truth only after taking an oath has not yet reached the ethical ideal Jesus presents.

Jesus moves the focus from:

“Did you use the correct oath?”

to:

“Are you truthful?”

This is one of the major theological movements of the Sermon on the Mount.

7. Matthew 5:33–37

Matthew 5:33–37 is the central biblical foundation for this research.

Jesus says, in summary, that his disciples should not swear in the ordinary manner and that their word should be simply yes or no.

The climax is:

“Let what you say be simply ‘Yes’ or ‘No.’”

This is revolutionary because Jesus does not merely give another oath formula.

He eliminates the need for an oath.

The disciple's ordinary word should be trustworthy.

The Christian does not need to say:

“Yes, and I swear.”

The Christian says:

“Yes.”

The Christian does not need:

“No, I swear before God.”

The Christian says:

“No.”

The strength of Christian speech comes from Christian character.

Jesus' teaching therefore changes the foundation of credibility.

The foundation is no longer:

“Believe me because I swore.”

It becomes:

“Believe my truthful word because I am committed to truth.”

8. Heaven, Earth, Jerusalem, and the Problem of Oath Formulas

Jesus refers to heaven, earth, Jerusalem, and the person's own head.

This is significant.

People could attempt to create different levels of oath seriousness.

One oath might invoke God.

Another might invoke heaven.

Another might invoke earth.

Another might invoke Jerusalem.

Another might invoke something less explicitly religious.

The underlying temptation is to say:

“This particular formula is not really binding.”

Jesus challenges this approach.

Heaven belongs to God.

Earth belongs to God.

Jerusalem is connected with the great King.

Therefore the human speaker cannot escape divine reality merely by changing the wording.

This teaches an important principle:

Changing the formula does not change the moral reality.

A person cannot make dishonest speech holy by changing the vocabulary.

A person cannot make a sinful commitment righteous by making it solemn.

A person cannot make a lie trustworthy by attaching God's name to it.

9. James 5:12

James 5:12 strongly reinforces the teaching of Matthew 5.

James says:

“Do not swear, either by heaven or by earth or by any other oath.”

Then he gives the alternative:

“Let your yes be yes and your no be no.”

This is extremely important for the present research.

James does not say:

“Find a better oath.”

He does not say:

“Use a more sacred oath.”

He says:

Let your yes be yes.

The Christian solution to unreliable speech is not stronger oath-taking.

The solution is truthful character.

James connects this instruction with judgment.

Words matter because God judges human conduct.

Therefore Christians should not use speech carelessly.

10. Human Imperfection

Human imperfection is one of the foundations of this theology.

Christian Scripture teaches that humanity is affected by sin.

Romans 3:23 states:

“All have sinned and fall short of the glory of God.”

This means that no human being can claim divine moral perfection.

Every human person remains capable of:

- error,
- temptation,
- selfishness,
- deception,
- fear,
- pride,
- anger,
- forgetfulness,
- weakness,
- misunderstanding,
- failure,
- repentance,
- and change.

Therefore, the human speaker cannot provide the absolute guarantee that belongs to God.

This does not mean that humans are incapable of good.

Christians can be truthful.

Christians can be faithful.

Christians can love.

Christians can keep commitments.

But human goodness is not divine perfection.

This distinction must remain clear.

11. Human Thoughts and Thinking Are Changeable

Your proposed argument gives particular importance to human thought.

Human thinking is not immutable.

A person may believe something today and understand it differently tomorrow.

New information can change judgment.

Experience can change perspective.

Fear can change decisions.

Temptation can change behavior.

Relationships can change priorities.

Circumstances can change plans.

Therefore a human being cannot guarantee that his or her present intention will remain identical under every future condition.

This is particularly important when an oath concerns the future.

Consider the difference between:

“I intend to do this.”

and:

“I swear that I will certainly do this regardless of what happens.”

The first statement acknowledges human limitation.

The second can imply an absolute certainty that the human speaker does not possess.

Christian humility therefore prefers truthful recognition of limitation.

12. Human Mutability

Human beings change.

This is not merely psychological.

Human bodies change.

Human relationships change.

Human societies change.

Human institutions change.

Human knowledge changes.

Human circumstances change.

Human decisions change.

Human emotions change.

Human desires change.

Human plans change.

This does not mean that humans are completely unstable.

A person can remain faithful.

A person can maintain a conviction.

A person can keep a promise.

But human constancy is not absolute.

Theologically, this distinction is essential.

God's faithfulness is divine.

Human faithfulness is creaturely.

God's promises rest upon God's character.

Human promises rest upon human character and circumstances.

Therefore:

A human oath cannot become divine merely because it is solemn.

13. Human Sinful Nature and Speech

Human sin affects speech.

Jesus says in Matthew 12:34 that speech comes from the heart.

This means that the problem of speech cannot be solved merely through external formulas.

If the heart is corrupt, solemn language can become a tool of corruption.

A dishonest person can swear.

A malicious person can swear.

A corrupt person can swear.

A person who intends to deceive can swear.

Therefore:

An oath does not cleanse the heart.

An oath does not remove sin.

An oath does not guarantee integrity.

The person remains the same person before and after the oath.

This is why the Christian ethic must focus on character.

The Christian does not become truthful by saying:

“I swear.”

The Christian becomes truthful through a life shaped by Christ.

14. Why Human Oaths Cannot Be Perfect

The central proposition of this paper can now be stated:

Human oaths cannot be perfect because human beings are not perfect.

The oath is spoken by the person.

The person is finite.

The person is changeable.

The person can sin.

Therefore the oath cannot transcend the limitations of the speaker.

A human oath may be:

- sincere,
- serious,
- honest,
- carefully considered,
- faithfully kept.

But it remains human.

It cannot become:

- omniscient,
- immutable,
- omnipotent,
- absolutely sovereign,
- morally infallible,
- or divine.

Therefore, a human oath cannot possess the absolute character of God's faithfulness.

15. The Difference Between Sincere Oaths and Perfect Oaths

This distinction is important.

A person can make a sincere oath.

Suppose someone says:

“I swear that I will help you.”

At the moment of speaking, the person may sincerely intend to help.

That does not mean the person is lying.

But sincerity is not perfection.

The person may later become ill.

The person may lose the ability to help.

The circumstances may change.

The person may become afraid.

The person may forget.

The person may become tempted.

The person may discover that the original commitment was based on incorrect information.

Therefore:

Sincere does not mean immutable.

Honest does not mean omniscient.

Faithful does not mean divine.

This distinction makes the argument stronger.

The argument does not need to accuse every human oath-taker of lying.

Instead, it identifies the theological limitation of human beings.

16. The Problem of Broken Oaths

A human oath can be broken.

A person can promise something and later fail to perform it.

There are many possible reasons.

Some are sinful.

Some are accidental.

Some arise from circumstances beyond the person's control.

Some arise from misunderstanding.

Some arise because the original promise was itself immoral.

Therefore every broken oath must be morally evaluated according to its circumstances.

A righteous promise broken through negligence may require repentance.

An impossible promise may require honest explanation.

A promise made under deception may require correction.

A sinful oath must be renounced.

This last point is especially important.

17. A Sinful Promise Does Not Become Righteous Because It Was Sworn

Suppose a person promises:

“I swear that I will harm an innocent person.”

Is that commitment morally binding?

Christian ethics cannot answer yes.

The oath itself cannot make evil good.

If the action is sinful, then the commitment to perform it is sinful.

The person should not say:

“I must commit evil because I swore.”

That would reverse moral authority.

God's moral will is higher than a human oath.

Therefore:

No human oath has authority to transform sin into righteousness.

This principle becomes especially important for the category of **evil oaths**.

18. The Evil Oath

An evil oath is a solemn human commitment whose purpose, content, intention, or effect is morally evil.

Examples may include an oath:

- to lie,
- to deceive,
- to frame an innocent person,
- to conceal serious wrongdoing,
- to participate in corruption,
- to persecute an innocent person,
- to commit violence,
- to destroy another person's life,
- to protect criminal wrongdoing,
- to provide false testimony,
- or to participate in an unjust conspiracy.

Such an oath may be solemn.

It may be emotionally powerful.

It may be socially enforced.

It may involve religious language.

But it remains evil.

The moral content of the commitment determines its moral character.

19. Oaths That “Hunt” Innocent Lives

Your expression that some human oaths “hunt” innocent life can be developed as an ethical metaphor.

The phrase should not be interpreted as claiming that spoken words possess an automatic supernatural mechanism that physically kills people.

Rather, it can describe situations in which human beings make solemn commitments that result in persecution, violence, false accusations, corruption, or other serious harm.

For example, consider a group that makes a solemn commitment to destroy the reputation of an innocent person.

The oath itself does not magically attack the person.

The people who made the oath carry out actions.

Their actions cause harm.

The oath can function as a mechanism of loyalty and coordination.

Therefore:

An evil oath can become an instrument through which sinful human beings organize destructive actions against innocent persons.

This is a serious ethical problem.

20. Evil Oaths and False Witness

False testimony provides one of the clearest examples.

Suppose a person knows that another person is innocent but solemnly promises to give false testimony.

The oath does not make the testimony true.

Instead, it adds solemnity to deception.

The result may be:

- imprisonment,
- loss of property,
- destruction of reputation,
- family separation,
- violence,
- social exclusion,
- or even death.

Therefore a solemn commitment can contribute to severe injustice.

Christian ethics must reject such an oath.

The proper Christian response is not:

“I must keep my oath.”

The proper response is:

“I must reject falsehood and tell the truth.”

21. Evil Oaths and Corruption

Corruption often depends upon secrecy and loyalty.

A group may attempt to make members promise never to expose wrongdoing.

Such a commitment may appear to demonstrate loyalty.

But Christian morality does not place loyalty above truth.

If loyalty protects injustice, loyalty itself has become corrupt.

Therefore:

A commitment to conceal evil cannot become righteous simply because it is solemn.

An oath cannot sanctify corruption.

An oath cannot sanctify injustice.

An oath cannot sanctify false witness.

An oath cannot sanctify persecution.

An oath cannot sanctify violence.

22. Evil Oaths and the Destruction of Nations

The statement that “evil oaths destroy nations” should also be understood ethically rather than as a claim that every oath possesses supernatural destructive power.

Human societies can be damaged when groups solemnly bind themselves to:

- corruption,
- political violence,
- persecution,
- discrimination,
- false propaganda,
- unjust warfare,
- criminal conspiracies,
- suppression of truth,
- or institutional abuse.

The oath can reinforce loyalty to the group.

The group then acts according to its commitment.

The resulting actions can damage individuals, communities, and nations.

Thus the destructive power is ultimately located in **human action organized around evil commitments**.

This is consistent with Christian moral theology.

Words matter because words lead to actions.

23. Divine Faithfulness

The contrast with human oath-taking becomes clearer when we consider divine faithfulness.

God's faithfulness is fundamentally different from human reliability.

God does not merely have a better memory than humans.

God is not merely more consistent than humans.

God is God.

Divine faithfulness belongs to divine character.

Therefore the certainty of God's promise cannot be reduced to the certainty of a human oath.

This is especially important in Hebrews 6:13–18.

The passage describes God making a promise to Abraham and swearing by himself.

The significance is that God has no greater authority by which to swear.

This demonstrates the uniqueness of divine oath.

God's oath does not make God more truthful.

God is already perfectly truthful.

The oath confirms the certainty of the divine promise.

Human beings are different.

Humans need no imitation of divine self-witness in ordinary Christian speech.

24. Divine Oath as a Theological Concept

Within this research framework, **Divine Oath** means the unchanging faithfulness, promise, and self-witness of God.

This phrase should be understood as a constructive theological concept.

It is not being presented as an exact biblical title.

The Bible explicitly teaches:

- God's faithfulness,
- God's promises,
- God's truth,
- God's oath,
- God's Word,

- Christ as the Word,
- and Christ as the “Yes” of God's promises.

These themes can be brought together conceptually under the expression **Divine Oath**.

The purpose is to contrast God's perfect faithfulness with human imperfection.

Therefore:

Divine Oath belongs to divine faithfulness; human oath belongs to finite human speech.

These cannot be equated.

25. Christ and the Divine Oath

The Christological center of the framework is particularly important.

John 1:1 identifies Christ as the Word.

John 1:14 describes the Word becoming flesh.

2 Corinthians 1:18–20 presents God's promises as finding their “Yes” in Christ.

Therefore Christ stands at the center of divine promise and divine faithfulness.

Within this theological framework, one may say:

Christ is the living embodiment and fulfillment of the Divine Oath.

This wording is more precise than simply claiming that Scripture gives Jesus the literal title “Divine Oath.”

The theological meaning is that Christ is the personal revelation and fulfillment of God's faithful “Yes.”

God's promise is not empty speech.

It is fulfilled in Christ.

Therefore Christ becomes the center of Christian confidence.

26. The Father, Son, and Holy Spirit: One Divine Faithfulness

Christian theology confesses one God: Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

Therefore, if the expression “one Divine Oath” is used, it should not imply three gods or three independent divine oaths.

The Father is God.

The Son is God.

The Holy Spirit is God.

Yet God is one.

Therefore the phrase “**one Divine Oath**” can function as a theological analogy for the unity of divine truth and faithfulness.

It should not erase the distinctions between the divine Persons.

The Father is not the Son.

The Son is not the Spirit.

The Spirit is not the Father.

But the divine being is one.

Thus the framework can say:

The one Triune God is one in divine faithfulness; therefore the Divine Oath is one, not three separate divine oaths.

Again, this is a theological formulation, not a direct biblical quotation.

27. Human Oath Cannot Enter Into Divine Perfection

A central error would be to think that human beings can place their oath inside God's divine perfection.

For example, a person might say:

“I swear before God.”

But this does not cause the person's human words to become God's words.

The person remains human.

The person's knowledge remains limited.

The person's character remains imperfect.

The person's future remains uncertain.

The person's oath therefore remains a human oath.

Invoking God does not transform the speaker into God.

This is the theological boundary between Creator and creature.

28. Human Oath Cannot Become Divine Truth

A human statement can be true.

But a true human statement does not become divine revelation simply because the speaker swears.

For example:

“The sun is shining.”

If true, it is true.

Adding:

“I swear before God that the sun is shining”

does not make the proposition more true.

The oath adds solemnity, not truth.

This demonstrates that truth does not depend upon oath-taking.

The Christian should therefore cultivate truthfulness itself.

29. Simple Truthful Speech

The third category of the framework should preferably be called **Simple Truthful Speech** rather than “Simple Oath.”

Why?

Because Matthew 5:37 and James 5:12 do not appear to recommend another kind of oath.

They direct the believer toward:

Yes.

and:

No.

Therefore the positive Christian alternative is not a weaker oath.

It is **truthful speech without oath**.

Simple truthful speech means:

- yes means yes,
- no means no,
- truth means truth,
- uncertainty is acknowledged,
- mistakes are admitted,
- commitments are made responsibly,
- and falsehood is rejected.

This is the heart of Christian communication.

30. Why Simple Truthful Speech Is Stronger Than an Oath

At first, refusing an oath may appear to weaken a person's credibility.

In reality, the opposite can be true.

A person whose ordinary word is trustworthy does not need to swear.

Suppose someone says:

“I will do this.”

If the person's character is known to be truthful, the statement is sufficient.

But if the person must repeatedly say:

“I swear.”

then the repeated oath may reveal a lack of ordinary credibility.

Christian discipleship therefore seeks a society in which people's words are trusted because of their character.

The strongest Christian testimony is not:

“I swear I am truthful.”

It is:

A life of truthfulness.

31. How Simple Human Speech Can Become False

Simple speech can fail.

It can become:

- false,

- empty,
- fake,
- broken,
- misleading,
- manipulative,
- or sinful.

But this does not mean that simple speech is inherently defective.

Rather, the problem is human sinfulness.

A person can say “yes” and mean “no.”

A person can say “no” while concealing the truth.

A person can make a promise without intending to fulfill it.

A person can sincerely promise and later fail.

Therefore the Christian must continually develop integrity.

The fact that simple speech can fail is not an argument for oath-taking.

Indeed, the same sinful person can fail after taking an oath.

32. Fake Oaths

A fake oath is one in which the outward form of solemn commitment does not correspond to the inward intention.

The speaker may use serious language merely to persuade another person.

For example:

“I swear I will help you.”

But internally the speaker has no intention of helping.

The oath is therefore theatrical rather than truthful.

The seriousness of the words does not change the dishonesty of the intention.

This demonstrates again:

Form cannot replace character.

33. False Oaths

A false oath is an oath involving intentional falsehood.

This is especially serious when God's name is invoked.

A person effectively attempts to use sacred authority to support human deception.

This is why biblical teaching treats false swearing seriously.

The speaker does not merely lie.

The speaker gives the appearance that God supports the statement.

That is a profound misuse of divine authority.

34. Empty Oaths

An empty oath is a solemn statement without substantive moral commitment.

The speaker may use dramatic language while having little intention of faithful action.

Such oaths can occur in:

- relationships,
- politics,
- religious environments,
- organizations,
- families,
- friendships,
- and public institutions.

The words sound strong.

The commitment is weak.

Christian ethics rejects this separation between speech and action.

35. Sinful Oaths

A sinful oath is not merely an oath that is broken.

It can also be an oath whose content is itself wrong.

For example:

“I swear that I will take revenge.”

or:

“I swear that I will never reveal this wrongdoing.”

or:

“I swear that I will help destroy this innocent person's reputation.”

The oath is sinful because its purpose is sinful.

The Christian must reject the commitment.

36. Evil Oath as the Final Form of Corrupted Human Commitment

Within the proposed framework, the evil oath represents the most serious form of corrupted human commitment.

The sequence can be described conceptually:

Human limitation → human weakness → sinful intention → corrupt speech → false or empty commitment → evil oath

This should not be interpreted as an inevitable sequence.

Not every human promise moves through every stage.

Rather, it describes possible forms of corruption.

The important theological observation is:

The more human beings attempt to make sinful commitments absolute, the more dangerous those commitments can become.

37. Human Oaths and the Illusion of Permanence

An oath often sounds permanent.

A person says:

“I will never change.”

But human beings cannot guarantee that they will never change.

A person may sincerely believe today:

“I will always think this way.”

But the human mind can encounter new information.

The person may grow.

The person may learn.

The person may repent.

The person may discover that the original position was wrong.

Therefore Christian humility allows legitimate change.

Repentance itself demonstrates that human beings are capable of changing.

A theology that treats every human oath as absolutely immutable could therefore create a problem: it could make repentance appear to be unfaithfulness.

But Christian faith teaches repentance.

Therefore human commitments cannot be treated as higher than moral truth.

38. Human Oath and Repentance

Suppose a person makes an oath to do something wrong.

Later, the person becomes convicted that the action is sinful.

What should the person do?

The Christian answer should be:

Repent.

The person should not continue in evil merely to preserve the oath.

The person should confess the wrongdoing.

The person should renounce the sinful commitment.

The person should seek to repair harm.

This demonstrates an important principle:

Faithfulness to God is higher than faithfulness to an evil human oath.

39. The Moral Priority of Righteousness

Christian faithfulness is not blind loyalty.

A commitment is morally legitimate only when its object is morally legitimate.

Therefore:

Righteous commitment should be kept.

Sinful commitment should be rejected.

False commitment should be corrected.

Harmful commitment should be renounced.

This prevents the Christian from treating oath-taking as an absolute moral category.

No human verbal commitment is higher than God's moral truth.

40. Oath-Taking and Human Fear

Oaths can also arise from fear.

A person may believe:

“They will not believe me unless I swear.”

This creates pressure.

The Christian response is to develop a community where ordinary truthful speech is respected.

People should be allowed to say:

“I do not know.”

“I am uncertain.”

“I made a mistake.”

“I cannot promise that.”

“I intend to do it, but circumstances may change.”

These statements can be more truthful than an absolute oath.

Christian maturity requires humility.

41. Oaths and Manipulation

Oath-taking can be used manipulatively.

A speaker may say:

“I swear before God.”

The listener may feel unable to question the statement.

But invoking God does not prove the human statement.

This creates a danger:

Sacred language can be used to pressure another person into believing something without sufficient evidence.

Christian ethics should resist this.

God should not be used as a rhetorical weapon.

42. Oaths and Abuse of Religious Authority

The danger becomes greater when religious leaders use oaths to control people.

A leader may demand:

“Swear that you will never question me.”

Such a commitment is spiritually dangerous.

Christian authority is not absolute human authority.

No Christian leader becomes God.

Therefore Christians should not be bound to sinful or abusive commitments.

A healthy Christian community should encourage:

- truth,
 - accountability,
 - conscience,
 - repentance,
 - justice,
 - and responsible freedom.
-

43. Oaths and Institutional Justice

Institutions require truthful communication.

Courts need testimony.

Governments need accurate information.

Families need honesty.

Churches need truthful reporting.

Organizations need trustworthy commitments.

But institutions should not confuse solemn language with truth.

An oath does not replace:

- evidence,
- investigation,
- accountability,
- justice,
- or character.

Therefore the Christian principle of truthful speech can actually strengthen institutions.

The question should not merely be:

“Did this person swear?”

It should also be:

“Is the statement true?”

“What evidence supports it?”

“Is the person credible?”

“Has the process been just?”

44. Legal Oaths

A careful distinction must be made between theological and legal categories.

The statement:

“Oath is a crime”

cannot be universally applied to every legal system.

Whether oath-taking is legally required, permitted, optional, or prohibited depends upon jurisdiction and context.

Therefore this paper does **not** argue that every oath is automatically a legal crime.

The theological argument is different.

It is:

Christians should not depend upon oath-taking as the foundation of truthful speech.

Where legal systems allow a person to make an affirmation instead of a religious oath, that option may correspond more directly to a strict interpretation of Matthew 5:33–37 and James 5:12.

Different Christian traditions have reached different conclusions regarding judicial and civil oaths.

This paper adopts the strict non-oath position while recognizing the existence of alternative Christian interpretations.

45. Oath, Promise, Commitment, and Covenant

The concepts of oath, promise, commitment, and covenant should not be confused.

A **promise** is a commitment to another person.

A **commitment** is an intention or obligation to pursue an action.

A **covenant** is a structured relational arrangement involving obligations and promises.

An **oath** is a solemn affirmation or commitment reinforced by special authority or witness.

Therefore the Christian rejection of oaths does not require rejection of promises.

Christians should make promises.

Christians should keep legitimate commitments.

Christians should be faithful.

The argument is simply:

Faithful commitment does not require oath-taking.

46. The Christian Should Make Righteous Commitments

The non-oath position should never be interpreted as:

“Christians should never commit themselves to anything.”

That would be incorrect.

Christian discipleship requires commitment.

Christians commit themselves to:

- Christ,
- truth,
- love,
- justice,
- holiness,
- forgiveness,
- service,
- faithfulness,
- and obedience to God.

The issue is how these commitments are expressed.

The Christian can say:

“I will follow Christ.”

without needing:

“I swear before God that I will follow Christ.”

The first can be completely serious.

47. The Christian Should Admit Human Limitations

Christian speech should include humility.

Instead of:

“I swear this will certainly happen.”

the Christian may say:

“I intend to do this.”

Instead of:

“I swear I will never fail.”

the Christian may say:

“I will seek to remain faithful.”

Instead of:

“I guarantee the future.”

the Christian may say:

“If God permits, I will do this.”

This is consistent with James 4:13–15.

Human beings should recognize that the future is not completely under their control.

48. Human Knowledge and James 4

James 4 warns against presumptuous confidence concerning future plans.

Human beings say:

“Today or tomorrow we will go into such and such a town and spend a year there and trade and make a profit.”

James challenges this certainty.

The point is not that planning is sinful.

The problem is pretending to possess absolute control over the future.

This principle directly supports the critique of human oath-taking.

An oath can sometimes express exactly this kind of excessive certainty.

The Christian should plan responsibly but remain humble.

49. Divine Certainty and Human Uncertainty

The contrast can be summarized:

Divine Reality	Human Reality
Perfect	Imperfect
Faithful	Capable of failure
Immutable	Changeable
Omniscient	Limited in knowledge
Sovereign	Dependent
Holy	Affected by sin
Eternal	Temporal
Absolutely trustworthy	Trustworthy only by grace and character

This contrast explains why a human oath cannot become divine.

50. The Fourfold Theological Framework

The proposed model can now be formally stated.

I. Divine Oath

The Divine Oath refers conceptually to God's perfect faithfulness, promise, truth, and self-witness.

It is grounded in God.

Christ stands at the center because God's promises find their "Yes" in Christ.

II. Holy Oath

Holy Oath refers conceptually to a human commitment intended to correspond to God's righteousness.

However, the category does not establish that Christians should actually take oaths.

A human commitment can be holy in intention without becoming divine in nature.

III. Simple Truthful Speech

This is the practical Christian alternative.

"Yes" means yes.

"No" means no.

The person speaks truth without oath.

IV. Evil Oath

An evil oath is a human solemn commitment whose purpose or effect is sinful.

It may involve:

- deception,
- false witness,
- corruption,
- persecution,
- violence,
- concealment,
- or harm to innocent persons.

51. The Fourfold Framework in Diagrammatic Form

The framework can be represented as:

DIVINE OATH

↓

God's perfect truth and faithfulness

↓

HOLY COMMITMENT

↓

Human intention toward righteousness

↓

SIMPLE TRUTHFUL SPEECH

↓

"Yes" and "No" without oath

↓

If corrupted by sin

↓

FALSE / EMPTY / CORRUPT COMMITMENT

↓

If directed toward injustice

↓

EVIL OATH

This is a theological model, not a formal biblical taxonomy.

Its purpose is to explain the relationship between divine faithfulness and human speech.

52. Why Humans Should Not Take Oath

The argument can now be summarized logically.

Premise 1

God is perfectly faithful.

Premise 2

Human beings are finite and imperfect.

Premise 3

Human beings are affected by sin.

Premise 4

Human thoughts, intentions, circumstances, and knowledge can change.

Premise 5

An oath does not remove human finitude or sin.

Premise 6

Therefore a human oath cannot possess divine perfection.

Premise 7

A human oath can become false, empty, broken, corrupt, or evil.

Premise 8

Jesus directs his disciples toward simple yes and no.

Premise 9

James repeats the same principle.

Conclusion

Therefore Christians should not take oaths but should practice simple truthful speech and righteous action.

53. The Argument from Human Imperfection

The argument can be stated more directly:

No human being is perfect.

Therefore:

No human being can produce a perfect human oath.

The oath does not become perfect because:

- the person says it loudly,
- the person says it solemnly,
- the person invokes God,
- the person invokes heaven,
- the person invokes earth,
- the person invokes family,
- the person invokes honor,
- or the person accepts punishment for breaking it.

The speaker remains human.

Therefore the oath remains human.

54. Human Thought Cannot Become Divine Immutability

Human thinking can be stable without being immutable.

This distinction matters.

A person can believe something for fifty years.

That does not mean the person's mind possesses divine immutability.

The person could still change.

Therefore:

Duration is not immutability.

Similarly:

Sincerity is not perfection.

Consistency is not divinity.

Determination is not omniscience.

This provides a philosophical foundation for the Christian non-oath position.

55. The Problem of Absolute Human Language

Human beings sometimes use absolute language:

“Always.”

“Never.”

“Forever.”

“Under every circumstance.”

Such language can be dangerous when applied to human ability.

A person may say:

“I will never change.”

But humans can change.

A person may say:

“I will never make a mistake.”

But humans can make mistakes.

A person may say:

“I will certainly do this.”

But circumstances can change.

Therefore Christian speech should distinguish between commitment and omniscient certainty.

56. Christian Humility

The non-oath position is ultimately an expression of humility.

The Christian says:

“I am not God.”

Therefore:

“I will not pretend that my words possess divine certainty.”

The Christian says:

“I am capable of error.”

Therefore:

“I will speak carefully.”

The Christian says:

“I am capable of sin.”

Therefore:

“I will guard my speech.”

The Christian says:

“I do not control the future.”

Therefore:

“I will make commitments responsibly.”

This is not weakness.

It is humility.

57. Truth Without Oath

Truth does not need an oath.

A mathematical truth does not become more mathematical because someone swears it.

A historical fact does not become more historical because someone swears it.

A truthful testimony does not become more truthful because someone invokes heaven.

The truth stands on its own.

Therefore Jesus' teaching directs the Christian toward speech whose truthfulness does not depend upon verbal reinforcement.

58. Oath as a Substitute for Integrity

An important ethical insight is:

Oaths can become a poor substitute for integrity.

If a person's ordinary word is not trustworthy, adding an oath does not solve the fundamental problem.

Suppose someone repeatedly lies.

Then the person says:

"I swear this time I am telling the truth."

The oath does not repair the character problem.

The person needs repentance and transformation.

Therefore Christian ethics seeks integrity rather than stronger formulas.

59. The Heart of Christian Truthfulness

Christian truthfulness has three dimensions:

1. Truthful Thought

The believer seeks to know what is true.

2. Truthful Speech

The believer speaks what is true.

3. Truthful Action

The believer acts consistently with truth.

An oath addresses primarily the second dimension, and even there it does not guarantee truth.

Christian discipleship addresses all three.

Therefore oath-taking is not the central solution.

Transformation is.

60. Truthfulness and Repentance

No human being will live perfectly.

Therefore Christian truthfulness must include repentance.

When a Christian lies:

confess.

When a Christian breaks a legitimate promise:

acknowledge it.

When a Christian harms another:

seek reconciliation and repair.

When a Christian makes an evil commitment:

renounce it.

This is superior to adding another oath.

The Christian response to failure is not:

“I swear again.”

It is:

“I was wrong. I repent. I will tell the truth.”

61. The Evil Oath and Innocent Persons

The protection of innocent people is a major ethical implication of the framework.

Suppose an oath is used to:

- falsely accuse,
- persecute,
- imprison,
- harm,
- silence,
- exploit,
- or destroy an innocent person.

The oath cannot be treated as morally sacred.

Christian ethics places truth and justice above corrupt human loyalty.

Therefore:

An oath against an innocent person is an evil commitment and must be rejected.

The Christian should protect the innocent rather than protect the oath.

62. The Oath and the Conscience

A person's conscience should not be enslaved to an evil oath.

If someone says:

“I swore, therefore I must do it,”

the Christian response must ask:

“What did you swear to do?”

If the answer is evil, the oath cannot have ultimate authority.

Conscience must be formed by God's truth.

The Christian is not morally obligated to obey evil merely because the evil was promised solemnly.

63. Can an Evil Oath Bind a Christian?

The answer developed by this paper is:

No, not morally.

An evil oath cannot create an obligation to sin.

If a person promises to commit murder, deception, persecution, or corruption, the Christian must reject the commitment.

This principle can be summarized:

A sinful promise cannot create a righteous obligation.

64. Human Oaths and Divine Judgment

James 5:12 concludes its instruction with the warning that believers may fall under judgment.

This gives oath-taking an eschatological dimension.

Words matter before God.

Therefore Christians should not manipulate speech.

The question is not simply:

“Can I technically say this?”

The question is:

“Is my speech truthful before God?”

This moves the Christian away from legalistic word games.

65. Beyond Legalism

Legalistic oath-taking may ask:

“Did I technically swear?”

Jesus asks something deeper:

“Are you truthful?”

This is the difference between external compliance and internal righteousness.

A person may avoid a technical lie while deliberately creating a false impression.

A person may manipulate an oath formula.

A person may speak half-truths.

Jesus' teaching therefore reaches beyond formulas.

Christian truthfulness requires integrity.

66. Theological Significance of “Yes” and “No”

“Yes” and “No” are ordinary words.

That is precisely their significance.

Jesus does not require extraordinary vocabulary.

He requires extraordinary integrity.

A Christian's ordinary language becomes sacred through truthful character.

The person does not need to make every statement religiously dramatic.

The Christian life itself should testify to truth.

67. The Christian Community Without Oaths

Imagine a Christian community in which people do not need to swear.

A person says:

“Yes.”

Others trust the person's character.

A person says:

“No.”

Others respect the answer.

A person says:

“I do not know.”

Others accept the uncertainty.

A person says:

“I made a mistake.”

Others encourage repentance.

A person says:

“I cannot promise that.”

Others respect the person's honesty.

Such a community would embody Matthew 5:37.

It would not need constant oath-taking because truthfulness would become normal.

68. The Christian Family

The principle also applies to families.

Parents should teach children:

“Tell the truth.”

not merely:

“Swear that you are telling the truth.”

Children should learn that honesty is expected regardless of whether an oath is present.

The family should become a place where truth is safe.

This reduces the psychological pressure to use solemn formulas.

69. Christian Leadership

Christian leaders have an especially important responsibility.

Leaders should not manipulate people through:

- threats,
- sacred formulas,
- coercive promises,
- forced loyalty,
- or demands for unquestioning allegiance.

Leadership should be characterized by:

- truth,
- humility,
- accountability,
- justice,
- compassion,

- and service.

The leader's "yes" should mean yes.

The leader's "no" should mean no.

70. Theological Summary of Human Imperfection

The argument may be summarized:

Human beings are finite.

↓

Human beings are mutable.

↓

Human beings have limited knowledge.

↓

Human beings are affected by sin.

↓

Human intentions can change.

↓

Human commitments can fail.

↓

Human oaths cannot possess divine perfection.

↓

Human oaths can become false, empty, corrupt, or evil.

↓

Therefore Christians should not depend upon oaths.



Christians should speak truthfully.

71. A Necessary Academic Qualification

A strong academic paper should avoid saying:

“Every human oath automatically becomes false.”

That statement is too absolute.

People can sincerely make promises and keep them.

The stronger formulation is:

No human oath possesses divine perfection, and every human oath remains vulnerable to human error, human limitation, changing circumstances, and sin.

This distinction improves the theological argument.

It also prevents an unnecessary contradiction.

If every human oath were necessarily false, then a sincere oath kept faithfully would be impossible.

But Christian experience clearly recognizes that people can be faithful.

The argument does not require denying human faithfulness.

It requires distinguishing human faithfulness from divine faithfulness.

72. Human Faithfulness Is Real but Limited

Human faithfulness is valuable.

A faithful husband or wife is valuable.

A faithful friend is valuable.

A faithful employee is valuable.

A faithful pastor is valuable.

A faithful citizen is valuable.

A faithful Christian is valuable.

But none of these forms of faithfulness are divine perfection.

Human faithfulness is dependent upon God's grace and human moral responsibility.

Therefore Christians should pursue faithfulness without pretending to be infallible.

73. The Christian Does Not Need to Become Omniscient

A person does not need complete knowledge to speak truthfully.

The Christian can say:

“This is what I know.”

rather than:

“I swear that I know everything about this.”

The Christian can say:

“This is my understanding.”

rather than:

“I swear that there is no possibility that I am mistaken.”

This is intellectually humble and morally responsible.

74. The Christian Does Not Need to Guarantee the Future

Humans cannot guarantee every future circumstance.

Therefore the Christian should distinguish:

intention

from

absolute guarantee.

For example:

“I intend to help you tomorrow.”

is different from:

“I swear that nothing can prevent me from helping you tomorrow.”

The first is a responsible human commitment.

The second can imply control over circumstances that the person does not possess.

Christian speech should respect this distinction.

75. Oaths and False Certainty

The phrase “false certainty” is important.

A person may be sincere but overly certain.

That person may not intend to deceive.

Yet the person can still make an unjustifiably absolute statement.

Oath-taking can reinforce this problem because solemn language creates psychological confidence.

Christian truthfulness requires not merely sincerity but appropriate confidence.

The person should speak according to the evidence and knowledge available.

76. Divine Promise and Human Promise

The distinction can be expressed as:

Divine Promise

- grounded in God,
- perfectly faithful,
- not dependent upon human weakness,
- fulfilled according to divine purpose.

Human Promise

- grounded in a human speaker,
- dependent upon human knowledge,
- vulnerable to human weakness,
- affected by circumstances,
- morally responsible but not divine.

Therefore human beings should never confuse their own promises with God's promises.

77. Christ as God's “Yes”

2 Corinthians 1:18–20 provides a particularly powerful Christological foundation.

God's promises are not presented as uncertain.

They find their “Yes” in Christ.

This is significant for the present research because Jesus' command about human yes and no can be understood in relation to God's definitive “Yes.”

Human beings say:

“Yes.”

Christ embodies God's faithful “Yes.”

The human yes is truthful because the Christian participates in God's truth.

But the human yes does not become divine.

The distinction remains.

78. The Divine Oath and the Human “Yes”

The theological relationship can therefore be described:

Divine Faithfulness

↓

God's Promise

↓

Christ — the definitive “Yes” of God

↓

Christian Faith

↓

Human truthful “Yes”

The Christian's yes is a response to God's yes.

It is not an independent divine oath.

This protects the distinction between God and humanity.

79. Why “Do Not Take Oath” Is a Positive Teaching

The phrase “do not take oath” may sound negative.

But Jesus' teaching is fundamentally positive.

It means:

Become truthful.

It means:

Become trustworthy.

It means:

Stop depending upon verbal mechanisms to establish credibility.

It means:

Let your character support your words.

It means:

Let your yes be yes.

It means:

Let your no be no.

Thus the command is not merely about what Christians must stop doing.

It is about the kind of people Christians are called to become.

80. The Christian Principle of Simple Speech

The Christian principle can therefore be stated:

Speak simply. Speak truthfully. Speak humbly. Speak responsibly.

Do not exaggerate.

Do not manipulate.

Do not invoke God unnecessarily.

Do not make promises you cannot responsibly make.

Do not swear to evil.

Do not use sacred language to conceal falsehood.

Do not force another person's conscience through an oath.

Tell the truth.

81. The Relationship Between Truth and Justice

Truth and justice are closely connected.

False speech can produce injustice.

False testimony can destroy an innocent person.

False accusations can destroy families.

False promises can exploit vulnerable people.

False commitments can support corrupt institutions.

Therefore truthfulness is not merely personal morality.

It is social justice.

A Christian theology of non-oath speech can therefore contribute to a broader theology of justice.

82. The Protection of Innocent Persons

One of the strongest practical implications of the framework is protection of innocent people.

If an oath is used to justify harm, the Christian should not honor the oath above the innocent person.

The Christian should seek:

- truth,
- protection,
- justice,
- accountability,
- repentance,
- and restoration.

The innocent person should not become a victim of a corrupt human commitment.

83. No Oath Can Sanctify Evil

This principle deserves direct emphasis:

No oath can sanctify evil.

No oath can make:

- murder holy,
- deception holy,
- false witness holy,
- persecution holy,
- corruption holy,
- exploitation holy,
- injustice holy.

The solemnity of the words does not change the moral content.

This is why the concept of evil oath is theologically important.

84. No Human Oath Can Become God's Word

Similarly:

No human oath can become God's Word.

A person may quote Scripture.

A person may invoke God's name.

A person may say:

“God is my witness.”

But the person's statement remains the person's statement.

Only God speaks with divine authority.

This distinction protects against spiritual manipulation.

85. The Danger of Taking God's Name in Human Oaths

When people invoke God to strengthen their own claims, they must be extremely careful.

If the claim is false, God's name has been associated with falsehood.

This is why biblical warnings against false swearing are so important.

The Christian should not casually place God's name behind human claims.

Instead, Christians should honor God's name through truthful lives.

86. The Oath as Human Attempt to Create Certainty

At a philosophical level, oath-taking can be understood as an attempt to create certainty.

Human beings know that their words may not be trusted.

So they add:

- sacred authority,

- consequences,
- witnesses,
- solemn formulas,
- or public rituals.

These are attempts to strengthen credibility.

But the fundamental problem remains.

The speaker is still human.

Therefore the oath cannot provide absolute certainty.

87. Christian Epistemic Humility

Christian theology therefore encourages epistemic humility.

The believer should distinguish:

- what is known,
- what is believed,
- what is intended,
- what is hoped,
- and what is unknown.

This is especially important when making future commitments.

The believer can say:

“I hope to.”

“I intend to.”

“I will seek to.”

“As far as I know.”

“If God permits.”

Such expressions can communicate truth more accurately than absolute oath formulas.

88. The Difference Between Faith and Human Certainty

Christian faith does not require pretending to have absolute human certainty.

Faith trusts God.

It does not transform human beings into omniscient beings.

Therefore the Christian can acknowledge uncertainty while remaining faithful.

This is another reason that oath-taking is unnecessary.

The Christian's ultimate confidence is in God.

89. Human Oath and Spiritual Pride

There can also be pride in oath-taking.

The speaker may imply:

“My word is so certain that I can guarantee everything.”

But humans cannot guarantee everything.

Christian humility says:

“I am responsible for my intentions and actions, but I am not sovereign over the universe.”

This is a healthier understanding of human responsibility.

90. Human Oath and Moral Responsibility

Rejecting oaths does not eliminate responsibility.

Quite the opposite.

The Christian remains responsible for:

- truthfulness,
- promises,
- actions,
- repentance,
- justice,
- and love.

The difference is that responsibility is not created by an oath.

A Christian should tell the truth whether or not an oath is present.

91. The Christian's Word

The ideal can be summarized:

Let the Christian's word become trustworthy.

When the Christian says:

“Yes,”

the Christian means yes.

When the Christian says:

“No,”

the Christian means no.

When the Christian does not know:

“I do not know.”

When the Christian cannot promise:

“I cannot promise that.”

When the Christian fails:

“I was wrong.”

When the Christian sins:

“I repent.”

This is mature Christian speech.

92. A Theology of Responsible Commitment

The non-oath principle does not eliminate serious commitments.

Instead, it creates a theology of responsible commitment.

Before making a commitment, ask:

1. Is this commitment righteous?
2. Is it truthful?
3. Is it realistic?
4. Do I have the ability to fulfill it?
5. Could circumstances reasonably change?
6. Am I being pressured?
7. Does this commitment harm another person?
8. Does it require deception?
9. Does it conflict with God's moral law?
10. Can I state the commitment simply and truthfully?

If the commitment is righteous, make it honestly.

If it is uncertain, qualify it.

If it is impossible, do not promise it.

If it is evil, reject it.

93. The Evil Oath and Group Loyalty

One of the most dangerous forms of evil oath occurs when a group makes loyalty itself absolute.

For example:

"I will protect this group no matter what it does."

This commitment can become morally destructive.

Christian loyalty must have limits.

Truth is higher than group loyalty.

Justice is higher than group loyalty.

Love of neighbor is higher than group loyalty.

Obedience to God is higher than group loyalty.

Therefore Christians must never allow an oath of loyalty to override righteousness.

94. The Evil Oath and Silence

Another dangerous form is the oath of silence.

A person may promise:

“I will never tell anyone.”

If the secret concerns harmless personal information, the ethical question may be different.

But if the secret concerns serious abuse, corruption, violence, or harm to an innocent person, absolute secrecy can become sinful.

Therefore an oath of secrecy cannot automatically override the moral duty to protect others and tell the truth.

95. The Evil Oath and False Protection

Sometimes people use an oath to “protect” a friend.

They may promise to lie for that person.

But false protection is not true love.

Christian love seeks what is good and true.

Therefore:

An oath to protect wrongdoing is not righteous loyalty.

True loyalty may require confronting wrongdoing.

96. Oath and Forgiveness

What should happen when an oath has been broken?

Christianity offers repentance and forgiveness.

The person should acknowledge the failure.

The person should seek forgiveness.

The person should make restitution where appropriate.

The person should learn greater wisdom.

This is preferable to attempting to hide the failure behind additional oath-taking.

97. Oath and Grace

The non-oath theology should not become legalistic.

Human beings will fail.

Christians need grace.

Therefore the principle:

“Do not take oath”

must be accompanied by:

“Speak truthfully, repent when you fail, and receive God's grace.”

The Christian life is not built upon perfect human performance.

It is built upon God's grace and human response.

98. Theological Implications for Christian Ethics

The argument has several broader implications.

First

Christian ethics should emphasize character rather than formulas.

Second

Truthfulness should be ordinary rather than exceptional.

Third

Human beings should recognize their limitations.

Fourth

God's name should not be used manipulatively.

Fifth

Sinful commitments should be rejected.

Sixth

Innocent persons should be protected from corrupt commitments.

Seventh

Christian communities should cultivate trustworthy speech.

99. Theological Implications for Christology

The framework also has Christological implications.

If Christ is the definitive “Yes” of God’s promises, then Christian truthfulness must be Christ-centered.

Christ does not merely teach truth.

Christ reveals God’s faithfulness.

Therefore the Christian’s truthful “yes” should be understood as participation in a Christ-shaped life.

This does not make the Christian divine.

It makes the Christian a disciple.

100. Theological Implications for Trinitarian Theology

The framework also emphasizes divine unity.

The Father, Son, and Holy Spirit are not three independent sources of divine truth.

God is one.

Therefore the phrase:

“One Divine Oath”

can be used conceptually to emphasize one divine faithfulness.

The Father promises.

The Son fulfills and embodies God’s promise.

The Spirit applies God’s work and bears witness.

The divine action is unified.

Yet the Persons remain distinct.

101. Human Oath Versus Divine Oath

The distinction can be summarized in another table:

Human Oath	Divine Oath
Spoken by finite humans	Grounded in God
Subject to human limitation	Perfectly faithful
Human knowledge is limited	God is omniscient
Human intention can change	Divine faithfulness is unchanging
Human beings can sin	God is holy
Can be broken	Divine promise is trustworthy
Can become corrupt	Divine faithfulness is righteous
May harm innocent persons	God's righteousness protects justice
Does not create truth	Expresses divine truth
Cannot become divine	Belongs to God

102. Why the Human Oath Must Not Be Worshiped

A person can become psychologically attached to an oath.

The person may think:

“Because I swore it, I must do it.”

But this can elevate the oath above moral truth.

The Christian must reverse the order.

The correct hierarchy is:

God → Truth → Righteousness → Human Commitment

not:

Human Oath → regardless of morality

Therefore no oath should become an idol.

103. The Christian's Ultimate Witness

The Christian's ultimate witness is not an oath.

It is a life.

Jesus teaches his disciples to become salt and light.

Truthful speech is part of that witness.

A Christian whose ordinary word is trustworthy gives testimony to Christ without needing to say:

“I swear.”

The life itself becomes evidence.

104. The Social Witness of Non-Oath Christianity

A Christian community committed to non-oath speech can become a witness to a different social ethic.

Such a community teaches:

- truth without coercion,
- commitment without theatrical solemnity,
- repentance without concealment,

- justice without manipulation,
- authority without abuse,
- and faithfulness without pretending to divine perfection.

This is a powerful ethical vision.

105. A Proposed Christian Vocabulary

The framework can be expressed through four phrases:

Divine Oath

God's perfect and faithful promise.

Holy Commitment

Human commitment directed toward righteousness.

Simple Truthful Speech

Ordinary yes and no without oath.

Evil Oath

A solemn commitment directed toward sinful purposes.

This vocabulary helps distinguish divine and human levels of speech.

106. Why “Simple Truthful Speech” Is Preferable to “Simple Oath”

For academic precision, this paper recommends replacing:

“Simple Oath”

with:

“Simple Truthful Speech.”

The reason is that the Christian alternative in Matthew 5:37 is not necessarily another type of oath.

Jesus says:

“Let your word be ‘Yes’ or ‘No.’”

Therefore the category should emphasize ordinary truthful speech.

This refinement makes the model more consistent with the text.

107. The Central Ethical Principle

The entire research can be reduced to one principle:

Truth does not need an oath.

And one further principle:

A human oath cannot become divine because it is spoken solemnly.

And one final practical command:

Do not take oath; speak truth.

108. Counterargument: Scripture Contains Oaths

One objection is that Scripture itself contains oaths.

This is true.

The Old Testament contains oaths and vows.

Hebrews 6 describes God's oath.

Therefore it would be inaccurate to say:

“The Bible never contains oaths.”

The real question is:

How should Jesus' teaching govern Christian practice?

The strict non-oath position argues that Jesus moves his disciples beyond reliance upon oath-taking.

Other Christian traditions interpret the passages differently.

This paper acknowledges the debate.

109. Counterargument: Jesus May Only Condemn False Oaths

Some interpreters argue that Jesus is primarily condemning deceptive or evasive oath practices rather than every formal oath.

This interpretation deserves serious consideration.

It is historically plausible that Jesus was addressing oath formulas used to manipulate obligations.

However, the strict interpretation points to the breadth of Jesus' language:

“Do not swear.”

James likewise says:

“Do not swear ... by any other oath.”

The simple yes/no alternative supports the conclusion that Christians can reasonably adopt a broad non-oath ethic.

110. Counterargument: God Himself Swears

Another objection is:

“If God swears, why can humans not swear?”

Hebrews 6:13–18 provides the answer.

God's oath is categorically different from human oath-taking.

God has no greater authority by which to swear.

God is perfectly faithful.

Humans are not.

Therefore God's oath cannot automatically be used as justification for human oath-taking.

Divine action does not always establish a command for human imitation.

111. Counterargument: Humans Can Be Faithful

Another objection is:

“People can keep their promises.”

Yes.

This paper fully acknowledges this.

Human faithfulness is real.

But human faithfulness does not equal divine perfection.

A human being can be faithful without being immutable.

Therefore this objection does not defeat the thesis.

112. Counterargument: Oaths Can Be Helpful

Oaths can sometimes have social functions.

They may express seriousness.

They may establish institutional trust.

They may mark important commitments.

This paper does not deny these functions.

The question is whether Christians should rely upon oath-taking as a spiritual foundation for truthfulness.

The strict Christian answer developed here remains:

No.

113. The Ethical Priority of Truth

When all arguments are considered, truth has priority over oath.

If the oath supports truth:

truth is still primary.

If the oath supports falsehood:

the oath must be rejected.

If the oath supports justice:

justice is still primary.

If the oath supports injustice:

the oath must be rejected.

If the oath protects innocent people:

the moral protection of the innocent is primary.

If the oath harms innocent people:

the oath is evil.

114. The Ethical Priority of Christ

For Christians, Christ is higher than every human oath.

A person should never say:

“My oath requires me to disobey Christ.”

If the oath requires sin, the oath must be rejected.

Christ's teaching on truthful speech therefore provides the higher moral standard.

115. The Final Form of the Thesis

The thesis can now be stated in its strongest academically responsible form:

Because every human person is finite, mutable, morally imperfect, and affected by sin, no human oath can possess the absolute perfection and immutability of divine faithfulness. Human beings may sincerely make and faithfully keep promises, but their commitments remain vulnerable to error, changing circumstances, temptation, sin, and failure. Consequently, oath-taking cannot transform human speech into divine speech or provide divine certainty. Some human oaths may become false, empty, corrupt, or evil, especially when they commit persons or groups to deception, injustice, persecution, corruption, violence, or harm to innocent persons. In light of Jesus' teaching in Matthew 5:33–37 and James 5:12, Christians therefore have strong theological grounds to reject oath-taking and instead practice simple truthful speech: let yes be yes and no be no.

116. Conclusion

This research paper has developed a biblical-theological argument for the Christian principle:

DO NOT TAKE OATH.

The argument begins with the nature of God.

God is faithful.

God's promises are trustworthy.

God's truth does not depend upon human weakness.

God's faithfulness is divine.

Human beings, however, are different.

Human beings are finite.

Human beings are mutable.

Human beings possess limited knowledge.

Human beings experience changing circumstances.

Human beings experience changing intentions.

Human beings are affected by sin.

Therefore human beings cannot produce a human oath possessing divine perfection.

A person may sincerely swear.

A person may sincerely promise.

A person may sincerely intend to fulfill the commitment.

But the person remains human.

The human oath remains human.

It cannot become divine merely because God's name is spoken.

This is why the distinction between **Divine Oath** and **human oath** is essential.

The Divine Oath, in this constructive theological framework, represents the perfect faithfulness and promise of the Triune God. Christ is central because God's promises find their definitive

“Yes” in him. The Father, Son, and Holy Spirit are one God; therefore the model speaks of one Divine Oath rather than three independent divine oaths. This language is theological analogy, not a claim that Scripture formally names the Trinity “the Divine Oath.”

Human beings stand in a completely different category.

They are creatures.

They are dependent.

They are changeable.

They can sin.

They can fail.

Their thoughts and intentions can change.

Their circumstances can change.

Their knowledge can change.

Their commitments can therefore fail.

For this reason, the human oath cannot provide divine certainty.

The problem becomes even more serious when an oath is corrupted.

A human oath may become:

- fake,
- false,
- empty,
- broken,
- manipulative,
- corrupt,
- sinful,
- or evil.

An evil oath is particularly serious when it binds people to deception, false testimony, corruption, persecution, violence, injustice, or harm to innocent persons.

Such an oath has no moral authority simply because it was solemnly spoken.

If a person swears to do evil, the Christian must not say:

“I must do evil because I swore.”

Instead:

“I must reject evil because God is righteous.”

If a person swears to lie about an innocent person, the Christian must not preserve the oath.

The Christian must tell the truth.

If a person swears to participate in corruption, the Christian must reject the corruption.

If a person swears to conceal serious wrongdoing that threatens innocent people, the Christian must not treat the oath as higher than justice.

Thus:

No human oath can sanctify evil.

Jesus' teaching in Matthew 5:33–37 provides the central positive alternative.

The Christian does not need an oath.

The Christian needs truth.

Jesus says:

Let your yes be yes and your no be no.

James 5:12 repeats the same principle.

Therefore the Christian alternative is not another type of oath.

It is **simple truthful speech**.

The Christian says:

Yes.

And yes means yes.

The Christian says:

No.

And no means no.

The Christian says:

I do not know.

And the Christian does not pretend to know.

The Christian says:

I cannot promise that.

And the Christian does not pretend to control the future.

The Christian says:

I was wrong.

And the Christian repents.

The Christian says:

I will seek to be faithful.

And the Christian acts faithfully.

This is the true strength of Christian speech.

The Christian does not become truthful by swearing.

The Christian is called to become truthful so that an oath is unnecessary.

Therefore the ultimate theological movement is:

Divine faithfulness → Christ's "Yes" → Christian truthfulness → simple "Yes" and "No."

And the ultimate practical principle is:

DO NOT TAKE OATH.

SPEAK TRUTH.

KEEP RIGHTEOUS COMMITMENTS.

REJECT EVIL COMMITMENTS.

PROTECT THE INNOCENT.

REPENT WHEN YOU FAIL.

TRUST THE FAITHFULNESS OF GOD.

The creature should not pretend to possess the certainty of the Creator.

The sinner should not pretend to possess divine perfection.

The human being should not attempt to transform human words into God's words through an oath.

Instead, the Christian should stand upon God's truth and speak truthfully.

Let your yes be yes.

Let your no be no.

Do not take oath.

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Final Research Proposition

Imperfect persons cannot take an oath possessing divine perfection because human beings are finite, mutable, and affected by sinful human nature. Human thoughts, intentions, knowledge, circumstances, and decisions can change. Therefore human commitments cannot possess the absolute constancy of God's faithfulness. Human oaths may consequently become false, fake, empty, broken, corrupt, sinful, or evil. When an oath is directed toward injustice, deception, corruption, persecution, violence, or harm against innocent persons, it must be rejected rather than obeyed. Jesus Christ directs his disciples away from oath-taking and toward simple truthful speech: "Let your yes be yes and your no be no." Therefore Christians should not take oaths. They should speak truthfully, make righteous commitments, reject evil commitments, protect innocent persons, repent when they fail, and trust the perfect faithfulness of God revealed in Christ.

[Blog Version]

Why Imperfect Persons Should Not Take Oaths

Human Imperfection, False Promises, and the Danger of Evil Oaths

Introduction

Every human person is imperfect.

Human beings can make mistakes, misunderstand situations, change their intentions, become afraid, act selfishly, or be influenced by power and circumstances. Christianity also teaches that humanity is affected by sin.

Because human nature is imperfect, human speech can become imperfect as well.

A person may say **yes** today and **no** tomorrow.

A person may make a promise sincerely and later break it.

A person may speak truthfully in one situation but change the meaning of the promise when circumstances change.

A person may make an oath with good intentions and later discover that he or she cannot fulfill it.

For this reason, the Christian teaching of Jesus is deeply significant:

“Let your ‘Yes’ be ‘Yes,’ and your ‘No,’ ‘No.’”

— Matthew 5:37

Jesus does not direct His disciples toward stronger and stronger promises. Instead, He calls them toward truthful and simple speech.

This leads to the central proposition of this blog:

Because human persons are imperfect and vulnerable to sin, they should not place their changing human words on the level of God's divine and unchanging truth.

An oath may appear to make a person's words stronger, but an oath cannot make an imperfect person perfect.

And when a human oath is used to support falsehood, corruption, crime, or harm against innocent people, it becomes an **evil oath**.

1. God Is Perfect, but Human Persons Are Not

The Christian understanding of God's faithfulness begins with God's perfection.

God does not have the limitations of human beings.

God is not subject to human weakness, ignorance, corruption, or changing circumstances.

Human beings are different.

Scripture teaches:

“All have sinned and fall short of the glory of God.”

— Romans 3:23

This means that human beings cannot claim the same perfection and absolute reliability that belong to God.

A person may sincerely intend to fulfill a promise and still fail.

A person may believe something today and learn tomorrow that the belief was mistaken.

A person may promise something without understanding all future circumstances.

A person may be pressured into changing his or her decision.

Therefore, the human person must remain humble about his or her own words.

2. The Divine Promise Is Not the Human Promise

This distinction is fundamental.

God's promise belongs to God.

A human promise belongs to a human being.

God is faithful.

Human beings are imperfect.

God's truth does not depend upon changing human circumstances.

Human understanding can change as circumstances change.

Therefore, a human oath cannot simply be placed on the same level as God's divine promise.

The Divine Oath, in the theological framework proposed here, represents the **living, holy, faithful truth and promise of the one Triune God**.

Human beings cannot reproduce that perfection through an oath.

They can only attempt to speak truthfully.

3. The Problem of the Imperfect Oath-Taker

Consider a person who takes an oath today.

At the moment of the oath, the person may genuinely believe:

“I will always do this.”

But human beings cannot completely control the future.

Circumstances can change.

Knowledge can change.

Relationships can change.

Responsibilities can change.

The person's understanding can change.

Even the person's own character can change.

The person may therefore discover later that the oath cannot be fulfilled.

This creates a serious problem.

If the person breaks the oath, the oath becomes unfulfilled.

If the person keeps an evil oath, the person may commit wrongdoing.

If the person changes the wording of the oath to suit the circumstances, the original meaning may be lost.

Thus:

Human imperfection makes absolute human oath-taking morally dangerous.

4. Words Can Change With Circumstances

Human beings frequently adapt their language according to circumstances.

A person may say:

“I will never do this.”

Later, circumstances change.

The person may say:

“I did not mean it that way.”

Or:

“That promise applied only to that situation.”

Or:

“The circumstances are different now.”

This demonstrates the weakness of human oath-taking.

An oath may begin with absolute language, while human life remains constantly changing.

The person may then reinterpret the words.

The meaning can gradually move away from the original declaration.

The result can be a false oath.

5. Human Imperfection Can Corrupt the Oath

An oath does not remove human imperfection.

If the person is dishonest, the oath does not make the person honest.

If the person is corrupt, the oath does not make the person righteous.

If the person is selfish, the oath does not make the person selfless.

If the person is ignorant, the oath does not give the person perfect knowledge.

If the person is sinful, the oath does not remove sin.

Therefore:

An oath cannot transform an imperfect person into a perfect person.

This is one of the central reasons for rejecting dependence upon human oath-taking.

6. Jesus Gives a Simpler Standard

Jesus says:

“Do not swear at all.”

He then says:

****“Let your ‘Yes’ be ‘Yes’ and your ‘No’ be ‘No.’”**

This is remarkably simple.

Jesus does not tell His disciples:

“Make stronger oaths.”

He tells them:

Speak truthfully.

The Christian standard is therefore not the strength of the oath.

It is the truthfulness of the person.

7. A Human “Yes” Is Not God's Divine “Yes”

This distinction is essential.

A human person says:

“Yes.”

But that yes is limited by human knowledge, human ability, and human circumstances.

God's "Yes" is different.

Paul teaches that God's promises find their "Yes" in Christ.

God's faithfulness is not equivalent to human reliability.

Therefore, Christians should not treat their own declarations as though they possess divine certainty.

The human person must remain humble.

8. Human Oaths Can Become False

An oath becomes false when the words no longer correspond to truth.

This can happen deliberately or unintentionally.

Deliberate false oath

A person knows the statement is false but swears that it is true.

Unintentional false oath

A person sincerely makes a declaration based on incomplete knowledge and later discovers that it was wrong.

Broken oath

A person intends to fulfill the promise but later fails to do so.

Manipulated oath

A person changes the meaning of the original declaration when circumstances change.

Each situation demonstrates the limitations of human speech.

The human person cannot guarantee perfect future faithfulness.

9. The Difference Between a Mistake and an Evil Oath

Not every broken human promise should automatically be called an evil oath.

A person can fail because of weakness, misunderstanding, or circumstances.

That is different from deliberately making a wicked commitment.

An **evil oath** involves a morally corrupt intention or purpose.

For example, a person may knowingly promise:

- to lie for another person;
- to conceal a crime;
- to give false testimony;
- to participate in corruption;
- to harm an innocent person;
- to protect criminals;
- to deceive a court;
- to manipulate another person's life.

Such a commitment is not merely imperfect.

It is directed toward wrongdoing.

10. What Is an Evil Oath?

Within this theological framework:

An evil oath is a human solemn commitment that intentionally supports falsehood, sin, crime, corruption, oppression, or injustice.

It may be called:

- a wicked oath;
- a sinful oath;
- a criminal oath;
- a corrupt oath;
- an unjust oath;
- an oath of falsehood.

The defining feature is not simply that the oath is strong.

The defining feature is that its purpose is evil.

11. Evil Oaths Can Hunt Innocent Lives

One of the most serious consequences of an evil oath is harm to innocent people.

An evil oath can become a mechanism through which several people cooperate against someone who has done nothing wrong.

For example:

One person makes a false accusation.

Another person agrees to support it.

Another person provides false evidence.

Another person promises to remain silent.

Another person uses authority to enforce the false story.

The innocent person may then suffer.

In this situation, the oath is no longer merely a personal promise.

It has become an instrument of injustice.

12. False Witness Is Especially Dangerous

False testimony can destroy lives.

A person may falsely accuse another person of a crime.

If that accusation is believed, the innocent person may lose:

- freedom;
- employment;
- property;

- reputation;
- family relationships;
- social standing;
- physical safety.

Therefore, a solemn promise to give false testimony is profoundly evil.

No oath can make false testimony righteous.

13. An Oath Cannot Make Evil Good

This principle should be stated clearly:

A solemn promise does not make an evil action good.

Suppose someone says:

“I solemnly promise to lie for you.”

The promise is not holy.

Suppose someone says:

“I swear that I will help conceal this crime.”

The oath does not become righteous.

Suppose someone says:

“I swear that I will destroy this innocent person's reputation.”

The declaration is evil.

The seriousness of the promise does not change its moral character.

14. Invoking God Does Not Sanctify an Evil Oath

This is particularly important in Christianity.

A person cannot make a sinful oath holy merely by saying:

“I swear before God.”

God's name does not sanctify falsehood.

God's holiness does not become attached to a sinful intention simply because someone mentions Him.

Indeed, deliberately using God's name to strengthen a lie can itself be a misuse of God's name.

Therefore:

The holy name of God cannot be used to make an evil oath holy.

15. The Divine Oath and Human Oath Are Fundamentally Different

The Divine Oath belongs to God.

The human oath belongs to an imperfect person.

The difference can be represented as:

Divine Oath	Human Oath
God's truth	Human declaration
Divine faithfulness	Human faithfulness
Holy	Vulnerable to sin
Perfect	Imperfect
Unchanging in divine character	Subject to human weakness
Source of truth	Must conform to truth

The distinction is therefore absolute.

Human beings must never confuse their own words with God's divine truth.

16. The Trinity and the One Divine Oath

Within the theological framework developed here, the Divine Oath belongs to the one Triune God.

The Father is God.

The Son is God.

The Holy Spirit is God.

Yet there are not three gods.

There is one God.

Therefore:

The Father, Son, and Holy Spirit are not three separate Divine Oaths. The one Divine Oath belongs to the one divine truth and faithfulness of the Holy Trinity.

This is a theological formulation rather than a direct biblical title.

Its purpose is to emphasize the unity of God's truth and promise.

17. Living Holy Words

God's promises can be described as **living holy words** because they originate in the living God.

Human words may fail.

God's Word does not fail because God is faithful.

The living holy Word is supremely revealed in Christ.

John's Gospel declares:

“In the beginning was the Word.”

And:

“The Word became flesh.”

Therefore, Christian theology connects divine truth with the living Christ.

The divine promise is not merely a sentence written on paper.

It is grounded in the living God.

18. Human Words Should Follow Divine Truth

If God's Word is the ultimate standard, human words must follow it.

Therefore:

Divine truth comes first.

Human speech comes second.

A human being should not attempt to establish a personal oath as though it were divine truth.

Instead, the person should conform his or her speech to God's truth.

This produces the principle:

Human speech must follow divine truth; divine truth does not follow human speech.

19. The Fourfold Framework

The theological framework can therefore be summarized:

1. Divine Oath

The living, holy, faithful promise and truth of the one Triune God.

2. Holy Oath

A human commitment that genuinely conforms to God's truth and righteousness.

3. Simple Truthful Speech

The ordinary “yes” and “no” commanded by Jesus.

4. Evil Oath

A wicked, false, corrupt, criminal, or unjust human commitment.

The first category belongs uniquely to God.

The second and third concern human response.

The fourth represents human speech turned against divine truth.

20. Why “Do Not Take Oath” Is the Safer Christian Principle

If human persons are imperfect, and if oaths can be broken, manipulated, falsely interpreted, or used for evil, then Jesus' teaching provides a safer path:

Do not take oath. Speak truthfully.

The Christian does not need to make an absolute guarantee about the future.

Instead, the Christian can honestly say:

“Yes.”

or:

“No.”

And if circumstances change, the person can explain the change truthfully.

This preserves honesty without pretending that a human person possesses divine certainty.

21. Humility Is Better Than Absolute Human Claims

An imperfect person should be humble.

Instead of saying:

“I swear that I will never change.”

the person can say:

“I intend to do this faithfully.”

Instead of:

“I swear that I know everything about this matter.”

the person can say:

“This is what I currently understand.”

Instead of:

“I swear this can never change.”

the person can say:

“This is my honest commitment under the circumstances I currently understand.”

Such language acknowledges human limitations.

22. The Christian Does Not Need to Control the Future

An oath often attempts to make a future commitment appear absolutely certain.

But human beings do not control the future.

James teaches humility concerning tomorrow.

Human life is dependent upon God's providence.

Therefore, Christian speech should avoid pretending that human beings possess absolute control over future circumstances.

The Christian can make responsible commitments while remaining humble.

23. When Circumstances Change

Suppose a person makes a legitimate commitment.

Later, circumstances change.

The Christian response should be truthful communication.

The person should explain:

“When I made that commitment, this was my understanding. The circumstances have now changed.”

This is different from deliberately deceiving someone.

The goal is not to escape responsibility.

The goal is to avoid pretending that human beings possess perfect knowledge of the future.

24. The Danger of Absolute Human Promises

Absolute promises can become dangerous when they exceed human ability.

Statements such as:

“I will never fail.”

“I will never change.”

“Nothing can ever alter this.”

may sound powerful.

But human beings are not omniscient.

Human beings are not omnipotent.

Human beings do not know every future circumstance.

Therefore, humility should accompany human commitment.

25. The Christian's Responsibility After a Mistake

What should a person do after discovering that an oath or promise was wrong?

The answer should not be:

“Because I swore, I must continue doing evil.”

Instead:

1. Recognize the mistake.
2. Confess the wrongdoing where appropriate.
3. Stop participating in evil.
4. Correct the harm where possible.
5. Tell the truth.
6. Seek reconciliation where appropriate.

A sinful oath cannot create an obligation to continue sinning.

26. An Evil Oath Does Not Bind a Christian to Evil

This principle is particularly important.

Suppose a person promises:

“I will protect this criminal organization.”

If the person later understands the wrongdoing, the promise cannot morally require continued participation in crime.

The person should reject the evil commitment.

Truth and righteousness have priority.

Therefore:

A promise to do evil has no legitimate authority to command continued evil.

27. Oaths and Conscience

Christian ethics involves conscience.

A person should not deliberately violate conscience by making promises that contradict known moral truth.

Before making a solemn commitment, a Christian should ask:

Is this truthful?

Is this righteous?

Could this harm another person?

Am I being pressured?

Am I promising something beyond my ability?

Could this commitment require me to sin later?

These questions can prevent serious moral consequences.

28. The Innocent Person Must Be Protected

Any system of promises, contracts, declarations, or oaths should ultimately be evaluated according to justice.

If an oath becomes a tool for harming innocent people, it has crossed an important moral boundary.

Christian ethics cannot place loyalty to a sinful agreement above the protection of an innocent person.

Truth must prevail over conspiracy.

Justice must prevail over corruption.

Righteousness must prevail over wicked commitments.

29. From Oath to Integrity

The deepest alternative to oath-taking is not silence.

It is integrity.

Integrity means:

I say what I mean.

I mean what I say.

I do not deliberately deceive.

I do not use God's name to manipulate others.

I do not promise evil.

I do not protect falsehood.

I accept responsibility for my words.

This is far stronger than an oath.

30. The Final Principle

The entire argument can be expressed in one sequence:

Human imperfection → unreliable absolute promises → possibility of broken or corrupted oaths → possibility of evil oaths → potential harm to innocent persons.

Jesus provides another way:

Truthful heart → truthful speech → “Yes” as yes → “No” as no → integrity → justice.

The Christian therefore has no need to elevate ordinary human speech into a divine guarantee.

Conclusion

Human beings are imperfect.

They are limited in knowledge, ability, understanding, and foresight. Christianity also teaches that human beings are affected by sin.

Therefore, human persons cannot possess the absolute perfection and faithfulness that belong to God.

An oath does not remove this imperfection.

A person can swear and still lie.

A person can swear and later break the promise.

A person can reinterpret the words according to changing circumstances.

A person can make an oath sincerely and later discover that the promise was impossible or wrong.

And, most seriously, a person can make an oath for an evil purpose.

Such an oath may support corruption, criminal conspiracy, false testimony, oppression, or injustice. In some circumstances, the consequences can reach innocent people whose lives are damaged by the false commitments of others.

Therefore, an oath must never be confused with holiness.

A solemn word is not necessarily a holy word.

A strong promise is not necessarily a righteous promise.

An oath before God is not necessarily truthful.

A human commitment cannot become divine merely because God's name is invoked.

The Divine Oath belongs uniquely to God—the one Triune God, Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. In the theological framework proposed here, the Divine Oath represents God's living, holy, faithful truth and promise.

Human beings stand beneath that divine truth.

They should not attempt to place their imperfect words on the same level as God's perfect faithfulness.

This is why the teaching of Jesus is so powerful:

“Do not swear at all.”

And:

“Let your ‘Yes’ be ‘Yes,’ and your ‘No,’ ‘No.’”

The Christian alternative to oath-taking is not irresponsibility.

It is **truthfulness**.

Not stronger oaths.

Stronger character.

Not elaborate promises.

Faithful conduct.

Not religious formulas.

Living truth.

Not loyalty to evil agreements.

Loyalty to God and righteousness.

Therefore:

Do not take an oath to make your word appear divine.

Do not use God's name to strengthen a human promise.

Do not make promises that bind you to evil.

Do not participate in oaths that harm innocent persons.

Speak truthfully.

Keep righteous commitments.

Reject evil commitments.

Let your Yes be Yes and your No be No.

For the imperfect human person, humility is better than an absolute oath.

For the Christian, **truth is better than an oath.**

Why Human Oaths Cannot Be Perfect

Changing Human Thoughts, Sinful Nature, and the Danger of False and Evil Oaths

Introduction

Human beings make promises every day.

They promise to remain faithful.

They promise to tell the truth.

They promise to complete a task.

They promise to protect someone.

They promise never to change.

Sometimes they strengthen these promises by taking an oath.

But there is a fundamental problem:

Human beings are not perfect.

Human thoughts change.

Human understanding changes.

Human circumstances change.

Human desires change.

Human decisions change.

Human relationships change.

Human intentions can change.

And, according to Christian theology, human beings are affected by sin.

Therefore, an imperfect human person cannot guarantee that an oath will remain perfectly true forever.

This creates an important theological distinction between **God's divine promise** and **human oath-taking**.

God is faithful.

Human beings are imperfect.

God's truth is perfect.

Human understanding is limited.

God's promise is grounded in His unchanging faithfulness.

Human oaths depend upon changing human minds and circumstances.

Therefore, this paper proposes the following principle:

Human beings should not take absolute oaths because imperfect and sinful persons cannot guarantee the perfect permanence, truthfulness, and faithfulness that an oath can appear to claim.

When human oaths fail, they can become **fake oaths, false oaths, empty oaths, broken oaths, or sinful oaths**.

When an oath deliberately serves wrongdoing, it becomes an **evil oath**.

The Christian alternative is the teaching of Jesus:

“Let your ‘Yes’ be ‘Yes,’ and your ‘No,’ ‘No.’”

1. Human Nature Is Imperfect

The starting point is the Christian understanding of humanity.

Scripture says:

“All have sinned and fall short of the glory of God.”

— Romans 3:23

Human beings therefore cannot claim the perfection that belongs to God.

A human person can sincerely desire to do something good and still fail.

A person can make a commitment with honest intentions and later discover that the commitment cannot be fulfilled.

A person can misunderstand the situation.

A person can receive new information.

A person's circumstances can change.

A person's desires can change.

A person's moral condition can change.

Therefore, human beings should approach absolute promises with humility.

2. Human Thoughts and Intentions Change

One of the central problems with human oath-taking is the changing nature of human thought.

A person may think:

“I will always do this.”

But later the person's thinking changes.

The person may discover new information.

The person may experience a new circumstance.

The person may develop a different understanding.

The person may become afraid.

The person may become selfish.

The person may be tempted.

The person may fall into sin.

Thus, the internal foundation upon which the oath was made may change.

An oath attempts to establish permanence through words.

But the human mind itself is not perfectly constant.

3. Human Knowledge Is Limited

Human beings also lack complete knowledge.

A person cannot know every future circumstance.

Imagine someone saying:

“I swear that I will do this regardless of what happens.”

But what if something happens that the person could not have anticipated?

The person may later discover that fulfilling the oath would produce serious harm.

The person may discover that the promise was based on false information.

The person may discover that keeping the oath would require another sin.

This reveals a fundamental limitation:

Human beings cannot make perfectly informed absolute commitments because human knowledge is limited.

4. Human Circumstances Change

Human life is constantly changing.

A person's:

- health;
- employment;
- family circumstances;
- finances;
- responsibilities;
- knowledge;
- relationships;
- legal situation;

- social environment

may all change.

Therefore, an absolute human oath can become difficult or impossible to fulfill.

The person may have made the oath under one set of circumstances and later face an entirely different reality.

This does not necessarily mean that the person deliberately lied.

But it demonstrates why human beings should not pretend to possess absolute certainty about the future.

5. Human Desires Change

Human desires can also change.

A person may genuinely want something today and no longer want it tomorrow.

This is a normal feature of human psychology.

But when the person has taken an absolute oath, the earlier desire has been turned into a solemn declaration.

The result can be tension between:

the former intention

and

the present intention.

The person may then be tempted either to break the oath or to manipulate its meaning.

Neither is ideal.

6. Human Oaths Cannot Become Divine Oaths

This distinction is fundamental.

A human oath does not become divine because it is solemn.

A human promise does not become perfect because it uses religious language.

A human declaration does not become God's Word because God's name is invoked.

The Divine Oath, in the theological framework developed here, belongs to the one Triune God.

Human beings remain imperfect creatures.

Therefore:

Human oath-taking cannot rise to the perfection of divine promise.

7. God's Promise Is Different

God's promise rests upon God's character.

God is not limited in the same way as human beings.

God does not possess the uncertainty of human knowledge.

God does not experience moral corruption.

God does not become unreliable because of changing human circumstances.

Therefore, divine promise and human oath must not be confused.

The distinction can be summarized:

God's promise → divine faithfulness

Human oath → human intention

Because the sources are fundamentally different, the reliability is fundamentally different.

8. The Problem of the “Constant Oath”

An oath often attempts to create a constant commitment:

“I will always...”

“I will never...”

“Under every circumstance...”

But can an imperfect human person guarantee such absolute statements?

Human beings cannot guarantee every future condition.

They cannot guarantee that their understanding will remain unchanged.

They cannot guarantee that their intentions will remain unchanged.

They cannot guarantee that their abilities will remain unchanged.

They cannot guarantee that they will never be tempted.

Therefore, an absolute oath may exceed the legitimate limits of human certainty.

9. When the Simple Oath Becomes Fake

The theological framework proposed here distinguishes **simple truthful speech** from the later corruption of human oath-taking.

A person may begin with an apparently sincere declaration.

But if the person later changes the meaning, hides the truth, or pretends that the original words still mean something they no longer mean, the declaration becomes **fake**.

The words remain.

The truth has disappeared.

This is an important distinction:

A statement can remain verbally intact while its truthfulness is destroyed by the speaker's intention.

10. False Oaths

A false oath occurs when the statement contradicts reality.

The person may know that it is false.

For example:

“I swear that I did not do it.”

when the person knows that he or she did it.

The oath does not make the statement true.

It merely adds solemnity to the falsehood.

This is why the biblical prohibition against false swearing is so serious.

11. Empty Oaths

An **empty oath** is a solemn declaration without genuine substance.

The speaker may use powerful words but possess no genuine intention to fulfill them.

For example:

“I solemnly promise.”

But internally the person has no intention of keeping the commitment.

The words are therefore empty.

The oath has become a performance rather than a truthful commitment.

This is especially dangerous when religious language is used to create the appearance of sincerity.

12. Broken Oaths

A broken oath occurs when the person fails to fulfill what was promised.

There may be different reasons.

Sometimes the person deliberately breaks the commitment.

Sometimes circumstances change.

Sometimes the person discovers that the promise was wrong.

Sometimes weakness prevents fulfillment.

Regardless of the reason, the situation demonstrates the limits of human oath-taking.

Human beings cannot guarantee perfect future performance.

13. Sinful Oaths

A human oath can also be sinful from the beginning.

Suppose someone promises:

“I will help you deceive this person.”

The commitment itself is morally wrong.

Or:

“I promise never to reveal this criminal activity.”

Again, the commitment is wrong.

Or:

“I swear that I will give false testimony.”

The oath is directly opposed to truth.

Therefore:

Not every human commitment deserves to be fulfilled.

A commitment must first be morally evaluated.

14. Evil Oaths

This leads to the fourth category in the theological framework:

Evil Oath

An evil oath is a human commitment that deliberately serves:

- falsehood;
- sin;
- crime;
- corruption;
- oppression;
- injustice;
- deception;
- persecution;
- harm to innocent persons.

The problem is not simply that the oath may later be broken.

The deeper problem is that its purpose is evil.

15. Evil Oaths Can Harm Innocent Persons

An evil oath can become particularly destructive when it involves other people.

Suppose several people agree to accuse an innocent person falsely.

One person makes the accusation.

Another promises to confirm it.

Another promises to hide evidence.

Another promises to remain silent.

Another promises to use institutional authority against the innocent person.

The group may regard their commitments as “loyalty.”

But loyalty to falsehood is not righteousness.

Their promises become instruments of injustice.

16. The Evil Oath Can Become a Weapon

Words can become weapons.

A false accusation can destroy reputation.

False testimony can destroy freedom.

A corrupt promise can destroy justice.

A criminal agreement can protect wrongdoing.

A secret commitment can isolate an innocent person.

Therefore, an evil oath can become a social weapon even though it consists only of words.

The consequences can be extremely serious.

17. The Connection Between Oaths and Corruption

Corruption often depends upon relationships of mutual protection.

A corrupt person may promise:

“I will protect you if you protect me.”

Another person agrees.

A third person joins.

Soon the group has created a network in which everyone has an interest in hiding the truth.

At that point, the oath or promise is no longer merely personal.

It has become institutional.

Corruption can spread because people become committed to protecting one another's wrongdoing.

18. The Connection Between Oaths and Injustice

Justice requires truthful speech.

If people make false commitments to support false testimony, justice becomes difficult.

An innocent person can be convicted.

A guilty person can escape.

A victim can be silenced.

A corrupt person can remain powerful.

Therefore:

An evil oath can contribute to injustice when it binds people together against truth.

The oath is not magical.

It does not itself create injustice.

Rather, sinful human beings can use solemn commitments as instruments through which injustice is organized and maintained.

19. Why Jesus Says “Do Not Swear”

This gives deeper meaning to Matthew 5:33–37.

Jesus says:

“Do not swear at all.”

Then:

****“Let your ‘Yes’ be ‘Yes,’ and your ‘No,’ ‘No.’”**

Jesus removes the need for artificial layers of credibility.

The Christian does not need to say:

“I swear before God.”

The Christian should simply speak truthfully.

This is both simpler and morally demanding.

20. The Simple “Yes” and “No”

The Christian alternative is:

Yes.

No.

These words are small.

But they carry enormous moral responsibility.

If I say yes, I should mean yes.

If I say no, I should mean no.

If circumstances later change, I should explain the truth rather than manipulate the original statement.

If I make a mistake, I should admit it.

If I cannot fulfill a legitimate commitment, I should communicate honestly.

This is integrity.

21. “Yes” Does Not Mean Omniscience

There is an important distinction.

Saying:

“Yes, I intend to do this.”

is different from saying:

“I guarantee that nothing in the future can prevent me from doing this.”

The first can be a responsible human commitment.

The second can claim a level of certainty that a human person does not possess.

Christian humility therefore allows people to make responsible commitments without pretending to control the future.

22. Human Imperfection Requires Humility

Because humans are imperfect, they should speak humbly.

Instead of:

“I know everything.”

say:

“This is what I understand.”

Instead of:

“Nothing can ever change.”

say:

“This is my present commitment.”

Instead of:

“I swear I will never fail.”

say:

“I will sincerely try to remain faithful.”

Such language recognizes human limitations.

23. A Christian Does Not Need to Swear to Tell the Truth

This is perhaps the simplest conclusion.

If someone asks:

“Are you telling the truth?”

the Christian should not need to respond:

“I swear before God.”

The Christian can simply say:

“Yes.”

The credibility should come from truthful character.

Jesus' teaching therefore shifts the focus:

from oath → to integrity

from formula → to character

from external guarantee → to internal truthfulness.

24. The Divine Oath and Living Holy Words

The contrast becomes especially clear in the concept of the Divine Oath.

The Divine Oath belongs to the living God.

Within the theological model developed here, the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit are one God.

The divine promise is therefore not three separate competing promises.

It is one divine faithfulness.

God's living holy Word is not comparable to a fragile human declaration.

Human words change.

God's truth does not become false because human circumstances change.

This is why divine promise stands above human oath.

25. Christ as the Living Word

John 1:1 identifies Christ as the Word:

“In the beginning was the Word.”

The Word is God.

The Word becomes flesh.

This gives Christian theology a powerful foundation for understanding divine truth as living.

God's truth is not merely an abstract principle.

It is revealed in Christ.

Therefore:

The Christian's truthful speech should conform to the truth revealed in the living Word.

26. God's “Yes” and Human “Yes”

Paul writes that God's promises find their “Yes” in Christ.

This creates a profound contrast.

Divine “Yes”

Perfectly faithful.

Human “Yes”

Sincere but limited and vulnerable to weakness.

The human “yes” should imitate divine faithfulness, but it cannot become identical to divine perfection.

Therefore, human beings should remain humble.

27. The Human Person Cannot Become the Divine Witness

A human being cannot transform himself or herself into an absolute guarantor of truth by taking an oath.

The person remains a creature.

The person remains imperfect.

The person remains capable of error.

The person remains capable of sin.

Therefore:

No human oath can possess the absolute authority and perfection of God's Divine Oath.

28. Why the Oath Can Become Corrupt

The sequence can be described simply:

Imperfect person

↓

Changing thoughts

↓

Changing intentions

↓

Changing circumstances

↓

Broken or reinterpreted promise

↓

False or empty oath

And when sin deliberately enters the process:

Sinful desire

↓

Corrupt intention

↓

Evil oath

↓

Deception

↓

Corruption

↓

Injustice

↓

Harm to innocent persons

This demonstrates why the moral danger is not merely linguistic.

It is spiritual and social.

29. The Fourfold Framework

The complete framework can now be stated:

1. Divine Oath

The living, holy, faithful promise and truth of the one Triune God.

2. Holy Human Commitment

A human commitment that conforms to God's truth and righteousness.

3. Simple Truthful Speech

The honest “yes” and “no” taught by Jesus.

4. Evil Oath

A false, empty, corrupt, criminal, sinful, or unjust human commitment.

The first is divine.

The next two concern truthful human response.

The fourth represents human speech turned against truth.

30. The Moral Test

Every human promise can be tested by three questions:

Is it true?

Does it correspond to reality?

Is it righteous?

Does it conform to God's moral will?

Is it responsible?

Can the person reasonably fulfill it?

If the answer to these questions is no, the person should not make the commitment.

31. What If a Person Has Already Taken an Evil Oath?

An evil oath should not become a reason to continue doing evil.

Suppose someone has promised to lie.

The person should stop lying.

Suppose someone has promised to conceal a crime.

The person should not continue participating in wrongdoing simply because of the earlier promise.

Suppose someone has promised to harm an innocent person.

The promise must be rejected.

The correct response is repentance and a return to truth and righteousness.

An evil promise cannot create a moral obligation to commit evil.

32. Breaking an Evil Promise Is Better Than Keeping It

This principle is essential.

Keeping every promise regardless of its content would produce absurd moral consequences.

Imagine someone promising:

“I will commit murder.”

Would keeping that promise be righteous?

Obviously not.

The same principle applies to corruption, deception, and false testimony.

Therefore:

The moral quality of the commitment must be considered before the obligation to keep it.

A sinful promise should be rejected.

33. The Christian Alternative

The Christian alternative can be summarized in seven words:

Truthful speech without unnecessary oath-taking.

This means:

- speak truth;
- avoid deception;
- avoid false promises;
- do not invoke God manipulatively;
- make responsible commitments;
- reject evil commitments;
- correct mistakes honestly.

This is the practical meaning of Jesus' teaching.

34. The Goal Is Not Perfect Human Speech

Human beings will continue to make mistakes.

Christianity does not require humans to pretend that they are incapable of error.

Instead, it calls them to truthfulness.

If you are wrong:

Admit that you are wrong.

If you do not know:

Say you do not know.

If you cannot keep a legitimate commitment:

Explain the situation honestly.

If you made a sinful promise:

Reject the sinful promise.

If your words harmed someone:

Seek to repair the harm.

This is much healthier than hiding behind an oath.

35. Truthful Humility Is Better Than False Certainty

An imperfect human being should not pretend to possess divine certainty.

There is wisdom in saying:

“As far as I understand...”

“I sincerely intend...”

“I will do my best...”

“I was wrong...”

“I don't know...”

These statements may sound less dramatic than an oath.

But they can be more truthful.

Christian humility recognizes the difference between human limitation and divine perfection.

36. The Final Principle: Do Not Take Oath

The argument can now be stated clearly:

Human beings are imperfect.

Human thoughts and intentions can change.

Human knowledge is limited.

Human circumstances change.

Human desires can change.

Human beings are vulnerable to sin.

Therefore, human oaths cannot possess the perfect permanence and faithfulness of God's Divine Oath.

Human oaths can become false, fake, empty, broken, sinful, or evil.

Some evil oaths can bind people together in corruption and injustice and can cause serious harm to innocent persons.

Therefore, Christians should follow the teaching of Jesus: "Let your Yes be Yes and your No be No."

Conclusion

The human person is not God.

Human beings are imperfect.

Their thoughts change.

Their understanding changes.

Their circumstances change.

Their intentions can change.

Their desires can change.

And their sinful nature can corrupt their speech and commitments.

Therefore, human beings cannot produce an oath possessing the absolute perfection and faithfulness of God's divine promise.

A human oath can begin sincerely and later become broken.

It can become false.

It can become empty.

It can become meaningless.

It can become sinful.

And when it deliberately serves falsehood, crime, corruption, oppression, or injustice, it can become an **evil oath**.

The consequences of an evil oath can extend beyond the people who make it.

False testimony can harm an innocent person.

Corrupt agreements can protect wrongdoing.

Criminal commitments can strengthen organized evil.

Deceptive promises can destroy trust.

Unjust commitments can damage families, institutions, and societies.

Therefore, the Christian should not place ultimate confidence in human oath-taking.

The alternative is the teaching of Jesus Christ:

“Do not swear at all.”

And:

“Let your ‘Yes’ be ‘Yes,’ and your ‘No,’ ‘No.’”

This does not mean that Christians should become irresponsible about promises.

It means that Christians should become **truthful**.

Do not promise evil.

Do not use God's name to strengthen deception.

Do not make absolute claims that exceed human knowledge and ability.

Do not bind yourself to wickedness.

Do not participate in commitments that harm innocent persons.

Instead:

Speak truth.

Make righteous commitments.

Admit human limitations.

Correct mistakes.

Reject evil promises.

Let your Yes be Yes.

Let your No be No.

The Divine Oath belongs to the perfect and faithful God.

Human beings are imperfect.

Therefore, humans should not attempt to make their own words equal to divine certainty.

The Christian does not need a stronger oath.

The Christian needs a truthful heart.

And where the heart is committed to truth, the simplest words can be enough:

Yes.

No.

Truth.

Faithfulness.

Righteousness.